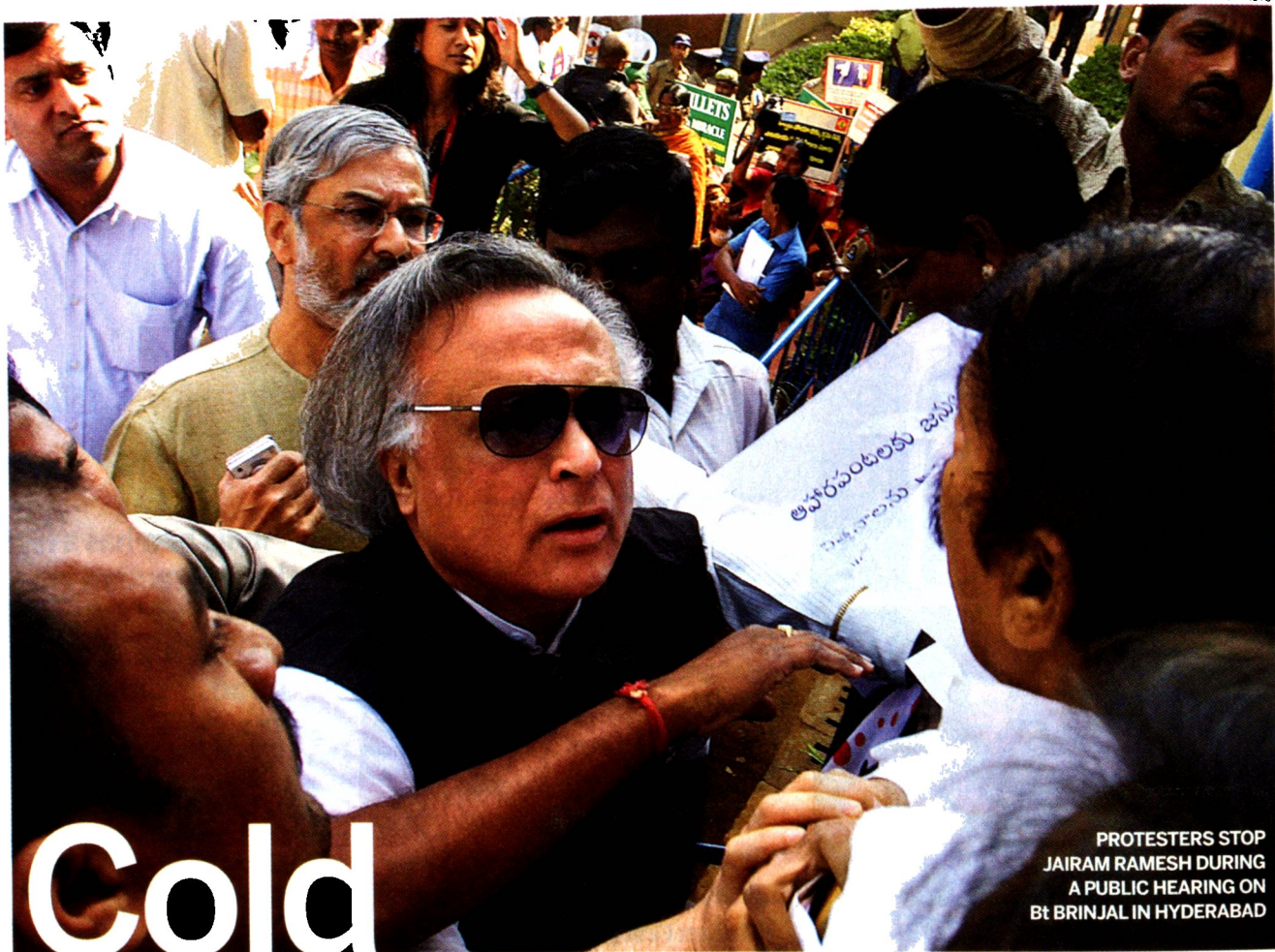




PROTESTERS STOP  
JAIRAM RAMESH DURING  
A PUBLIC HEARING ON  
Bt BRINJAL IN HYDERABAD

# Cold STORAGE

What passed the test of science has been shelved in the face of politics and environmental lobbies

| By Amarnath K. Menon |



He made it look like a street fight of which he was the referee and, finally, took a pedestrian and popular call.

Environment Minister Jairam Ramesh has put *Bacillus thuringiensis* brinjal in the freezer. After the dramatic build-up for the purported public hearings in seven cities that turned out to be protest gatherings, the minister has imposed a moratorium on the commercialisation of Bt brinjal until long-term scientific studies establish its safety

impact on human health and the environment. He gave in to the loud and raucous rather than pay heed to the logical and reasonable.

"It was a difficult decision. I had to balance science and society, producers and consumers, and Centre and state. As a responsible minister, I have to take a considered decision," says the defensive Ramesh who advanced his verdict on the pest-resistant genetically modified (GM) Bt brinjal by a day.

What passed the test of science with the experts of the Genetic Engineering Approval Committee (GEAC), which had given its nod for commercial cultivation, failed to muster any support in politics. Those who have often brushed aside issues of science and environment as technical held forth to the glee of the anti-GM lobby. As many as 10 chief ministers spoke against its commercial release until there are reliable safeguards for the farmers growing

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JAIRAM RAMESH, *environment minister*